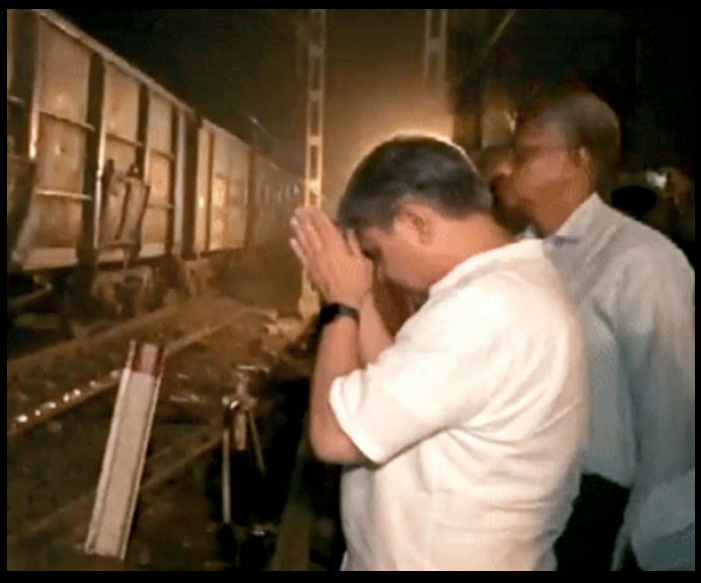




While helping the injured get treatment and assisting the kin of the dead, Vaishnaw also focused on **getting the trains running again in a record 51 hours**

that reports to the civil aviation ministry, began the arduous task of figuring out how the mishap occurred and who was responsible for it.

WHO IS TO BLAME?

On June 4, two days after the gruesome accident, Vaishnaw, in an interview to national broadcaster Doordarshan, said, "The CRS was at the site yesterday and has taken the statements of all the people and has proceeded fast. The root cause has been identified, the people who have done this work have also been identified." West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee, a former Union railway minister herself, soon after visiting the site on June 3 had claimed that the accident could have been avoided had the train been fitted with an anti-collision device. When asked about it, Vaishnaw said: "I want to clarify that this accident is not about the collision avoidance system. Whoever has done this has done such a change—on the point machine, the configuration of the track based on which everything runs and because of which this painful accident happened. But I will comment on that only after the report of the independent agency is submitted." Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who visited the site the same day, promised to take stringent action against those found guilty.

Two days after the crash, Jaya Varma Sinha, member (operations & business development), Railway Board, disclosed to the press that Coromandel Express's loco pilot, who later slipped into a critical condition, had revealed minutes after the accident that the signal on the main line of the tracks at the Bahanaga Bazar station was green. This suggested that the problem was possibly related to malfunctioning in the electronic interlocking signalling, which failed to detect the error and stop the train from proceeding long before it reached the station. "The system is 99.9 per cent error-free, but there is always a 0.1 per cent chance for error," Sinha said. She didn't rule out sabotage either. The next day, the investigation was handed over to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), after a government official suggested "deliberate interference" in the signalling system, necessitating a thorough investigation.

It now seems clear that there was a contradiction in the signalling situation. There was also a major violation on the part of the signal inspector and the station master after the new boom barrier was fixed and fresh connections with the electronic interlocking system made. They failed to carry out the physical verification, whereby the station master should have pushed the buttons on his control panel and got affirmation from the signal inspector that everything was working fine. A standard operating procedure, it mandates that a record be maintained of such a verification. According to sources, preliminary investigation suggests no such verification was done. This suggests that both the station master and the signal inspector were guilty of dereliction of duty. What has also amazed railway officials is how there could be manual interference with the electronic relay system so that it managed to send out faulty orders. These, in turn, overruled the command to permit the Coromandel Express to continue on the main line, and shunted it instead to the loop. All the signals too showed green when they should have been red. The CBI will probe if this action of the signal inspector and his team was a simple lapse of judgement or something else.

A.K. Mahanta, senior section engineer of signals and communications, and whose department is being blamed for the faulty signalling, strikes a dissenting note. He was part of the five-member joint inspection team that submitted a report on the crash. Mahanta argues the data logger, which